

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Superintendent salaries don't reflect districts



Superintendent Kevin Nohelty attends a Dolton West School District 148 board meeting, March 25 in Riverdale. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Compensation often not linked to school size, wealth or student performance

By Hope Moses
Chicago Tribune

In a small south suburban school district in Illinois — Dolton School District 148 — a fifth of the students met state reading requirements in 2024. The predominantly Black community has faced economic challenges for years, including property tax hikes. Yet, the former superintendent of their district earned a total compensation of more than \$537,000 last year, according to state records. Kevin Nohelty, who was the

district's superintendent for seven years until his abrupt retirement in August, earned a base salary of \$450,000, with an additional \$87,000 in retirement benefits and other perks. This made him the highest-paid superintendent in the state in 2024, with a paycheck bigger than the president of the United States and the Illinois governor. By comparison, former Chicago Public Schools CEO Pedro Martinez earned roughly \$356,000 in total compensation in 2024 while overseeing more than 600 schools with 300,000 plus students. That is roughly \$180,000 less for overseeing more than 100 times as many kids as Nohelty's former district. Given a superintendent's role in shaping academic outcomes, managing budgets and leading

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district strategic planning, it is reasonable to expect compensation to be linked to the district's size, wealth or student performance, experts say. But the data tells a different story. A Tribune analysis of 2024 salaries found that at least 18 suburban superintendents in Illinois received higher compensation than Martinez despite overseeing significantly smaller districts. Collectively, these 18 superintendents oversee 117 schools serving 76,000 students — roughly 600 fewer schools and 230,000 fewer

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Megan and Jarrett Szczesny sit outside with Coors, their 3-year-old Bernese mountain dog, at Homeslice on Sunday in Chicago. Ald. Timmy Knudsen, 43rd, plans to introduce an ordinance clearing the way for dog owners to bring their pets inside Chicago restaurants. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Dogs in restaurants?

Chicago ordinance would open door to man's best friend

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

When Josh Iachelli heads out the door to eat near his home, his two miniature golden retrievers, Chad and Derek, sit and stare. It's a heartache Iachelli might soon get to avoid as aldermen weigh a proposal to let restaurants and cafes welcome dogs. Ald. Timmy Knudsen, 43rd, plans to

introduce an ordinance Thursday clearing the way for dog owners to bring their pups inside Chicago eateries. Owners of the small businesses in pet-dense areas say the opt-in change could be a boon. "Pet lovers feel guilty leaving their dogs at home," said Iachelli, who co-owns the bustling Happy Camper, Paradise Park and Homeslice restaurants. "If you have a pet, you want to be able to have those guys with you more hours of the day." Iachelli said he would use the ordinance to make sure his spots "always have room for pets," an effort he has already made at his popular restaurants' patios. The currently allowed outside "dog-friendly areas" his locations feature have helped customers feel like they have their "complete family" in tow, he said. And the dogs seem to like it too.

"They come in, they sit under the table and they're just happy to get some extra love and attention," Iachelli said. Navigating the city's dog-related rules has been a challenge for Sophie Evanoff, owner of Lincoln Park's Vanille Patisserie. Evanoff did not welcome customers to sit inside with dogs, but did allow them to grab pick-up orders with their pets. She has never had an unruly dog in her dessert shop, where food is kept packaged or in cases. "To grab a coffee to go, two to five minutes, I don't see how that is an issue," she said. But last winter, someone complained twice to the city's Health Department

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Palestinian state push grows inside UN

At General Assembly, France latest nation to offer endorsement

By Joseph Krauss
and Farnoush Amiri
Associated Press

UNITED NATIONS — France recognized Palestinian statehood on Monday at the start of a high-profile meeting at the United Nations aimed at galvanizing support for a two-state solution to the Mideast conflict. More nations are expected to follow, in defiance of Israel and the United States. French President Emmanuel Macron's announcement in the U.N. General Assembly hall received loud applause from the more than 140 leaders in attendance. The Palestinian delegation, including its U.N. ambassador, Riyadh Mansour, could be seen standing and applauding as the declaration was made. Mahmoud Abbas, the Palestinian president, was seen applauding on a live-camera view after the U.S. government banned him and dozens of other senior Palestinian officials from attending the U.N. gathering in person. "True to the historic commitment of my country to the Middle East, to peace between the Israelis and the Palestinians, this is why I declare that today, France recognizes the state of Palestine," Macron said. The meeting and expanded recognition of Palestinian statehood are expected to have little if any actual impact on the ground, where Israel is waging another major offensive in the Gaza Strip and expanding settlements in the occupied West Bank. Macron announced recognition of the state of Palestine at the start of the meeting, at which several world leaders were expected to speak, includ-

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Tribune photographer describes making image that went viral

Stacey Wescott and on-site reporter Caroline Kubzansky reflect on what happened that morning that led to the image. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Developers: Adjusting to tariffs not gotten easier

Industry leaders say difficult to predict prices, start projects

By Brian J. Rogal
Chicago Tribune

The night before the Trump administration began enforcing a 25% tariff on Canadian imports, Chicago-based GI Stone had 13 trucks at the U.S. border, each loaded down with specialized granite set for installation in the Obama Presidential Center under construction in Jackson Park. Only eight trucks made it

through before the tariffs took effect on March 4. "We rushed all the trucks we could get," said Sandya Dandamudi, GI Stone's president and owner. "But there was a lot of congestion and long lines, so everything took a long time to process. For us, the tariffs have been a bit of a nightmare, and the biggest problem is the chaos." Adjusting to the tariffs imposed on Canada and other countries has not gotten easier over the past six months. The White House has imposed or canceled tariffs on nations with little or no notice, sending up and down the costs of

key imported building materials such as steel, aluminum, copper and lumber. Construction industry leaders say the tariffs have made it more difficult to predict prices, secure financing and kick off new development. And even though short-term fixes, including stockpiling inventory, have so far helped developers and contractors avoid passing along cost increases to consumers, tariffs will ultimately mean higher rents and housing costs. "The uncertainty is worrying builders," said Molly McShane, CEO of The McShane Cos., a national real estate and develop-

ment firm. "People understand deals won't move forward if prices change four times a week." Administration officials say tariffs encourage domestic sourcing and manufacturing. The administration also says tariffs boost job creation and tax collections, while encouraging more consumers to buy American-made products. "Large and persistent annual U.S. goods trade deficits have led to the hollowing out of our manufacturing base; resulted in a lack of incentive to increase advanced

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